Module 3 · Workbook answers

Communication

Video: 45 min **Answer sheet**

Module 1 laid the foundation (Allah is with you, hears you and sees you) and Module 2 added visualisation. This module adds the third stage, communication: speaking to Allah with an open heart, bringing Him your sins, blessings, needs, problems and decisions, so that your salah becomes the place where your burdens are lifted rather than the place where they distract you.

Answer sheet: the answers are in red. The reflection questions are personal, so your own answers will be in your own words and from your own life. These model answers show what the session teaches, to guide and check your thinking.

Key teachings

1. **Revision: presence has to be tasted**

   Presence with Allah is mentioned often but rarely taught, and it cannot stay theory; you have to practise it until you actually taste it. When tazkiyah (purifying the soul) gets difficult, that taste is what keeps you going. Stage 1 was the foundation from Surah Ta-Ha 20:46: Allah is with you, Allah sees you, Allah hears you. Stage 2 was visualisation, the first half of the hadith on ihsan (excellence in worship): worship Allah as if you see Him, starting with thought, then a picture you create, such as the name of Allah, the Ka'bah, Madinah, a mountain or the ocean. After this module come the mountain diagram, repentance in detail and the du'a of light (du'a al-nur).

2. **Stage three: speaking with Allah with an open heart**

   You cannot say "Allahu akbar" and start talking in English; that would break the prayer, which has set words. But you can speak to Allah in your heart. The Companions asked whether their Lord was near, so they could whisper to Him (munajat, intimate conversation), or far, so they should call out, and Allah answered: "I am near" (2:186). So pour out what is weighing on your heart and mind: problems, health, needs, blessings, anything at all. Many people struggle because they long for someone to listen, and some pay a counsellor simply to sit and listen. Allah is always listening, so do not keep it inside; get used to telling Him.

3. **Salah solves problems, and is gratitude and forgiveness**

   Whenever something distressed the Prophet ﷺ, he turned to prayer. Notice the shift in mentality: the spreadsheet that will not balance, the child's tantrum or the broken-down car is a reason to go to salah, not a reason to say "I've not got time to pray." The Prophet ﷺ also stood in prayer at night until his feet swelled, and when asked why, he said, "Should I not be a grateful servant?" (prophets do not sin; this was pure gratitude). And prayer is forgiveness: the five prayers, Friday to Friday and Ramadan to Ramadan wipe out what is between them, as long as major sins are avoided. There is a special salat al-tawbah (prayer of repentance), but every prayer is already a source of forgiveness.

4. **"Distractions" can become communication**

   We worry that thoughts in prayer mean we are failing, but this will change how you see it. In Sahih al-Bukhari, the Prophet ﷺ finished a prayer and hurried into his house, then explained that he had remembered a piece of gold there and did not want it to stay overnight, so he had it given away. It is reported that Umar would even organise his armies while in prayer. The thought itself is not the problem; it is what you do with it. Bring it to Allah.

5 **Lessons from whatever happens in prayer**

Learning Arabic is a great help, because the ayahs of the Qur'an themselves answer your problems. Even without it, a present heart can draw meaning from what happens around you. If your little child is crying while you pray, notice that even when a parent pushes them away, they keep coming back. You are the rabb (lord, carer) of your house to them; so ask yourself, why am I not crying like that for my Lord? These are the meanings you find when you go into salah with the right mindset.

6 **Practise all day and become a friend of Allah**

None of this needs words out loud, so practise it all day: while driving, while cooking, in any situation. You will get better, and eventually Allah becomes your closest friend. The awliya (friends of Allah) have no fear and do not grieve, and they have two qualities: they believe, and they are conscious of Allah (10:62–63). Allah says, in a hadith qudsi in Sahih al-Bukhari, that whoever shows enmity to a friend of His, He declares war on them. Imagine that closeness.

7 **The structured practice: opening**

1. Come into presence: picture the name of Allah in the sky, full of light, shining down until your whole body is full of light, with every cell praising Allah, because everything glorifies Him though we do not understand how (17:44). If the name is hard, use the ocean, a mountain or the Ka'bah. Bring in the three keys: Allah is with you, sees you and hears you. 2. Say Bismillah al-Rahman al-Rahim, because anything not begun in Allah's name is cut off from goodness. 3. Say Astaghfirullah three times, so no sin stands as a barrier. 4. Send blessings on the Prophet ﷺ, in whatever way you are used to, thanking the means through whom we learnt all this. 5. Say la hawla wa la quwwata illa billah (there is no power or strength except with Allah) three times. This is an invitation from Allah; you are simply answering His call, and your effort is tiny compared with what comes from Him.

8 **Five things to bring, then the hot air balloon**

Sins: present your biggest sins one at a time, even the ones you have not forgiven yourself for, regretfully, and ask forgiveness; seven if you can, or just the one that burdens you (39:53). Blessings: thank Allah for one blessing at a time (your eyes, ears, children, home, health); even modern gratitude journals recognise how much this helps, and the speaker's father falls asleep saying alhamdulillah for one blessing after another (14:7). Needs: things in the future, like a project deadline. Problems: things happening now, like the children, the car, a spouse; "O Allah, You fix this, and fix me." Decisions: a new car, moving house or school, a job, a course; Allah knows every outcome. Finally, put everything into a hot air balloon, watch it rise to Allah and feel the burden lift off your chest. In the salah you can bring whichever fits the day, and there are specific prayers for some: salat al-tawbah, salat al-hajah (for a need) and salat al-istikhara (for guidance). Now this time with Allah is a choice; in Jannah the people will praise Allah as naturally as breathing. You can do this with your children too: remind them that their parents are not in control; Allah is their Creator.

From the Qur'an and the Sunnah

وَإِذَا سَأَلَكَ عِبَادِى عَنِّى فَإِنِّى قَرِيبٌ ۖ أُجِيبُ دَعْوَةَ ٱلدَّاعِ إِذَا دَعَانِ

And when My servants ask you, [O Muḥammad], concerning Me - indeed I am near. I respond to the invocation of the supplicant when he calls upon Me.

Surah al-Baqarah 2:186

> *Whenever something distressed the Prophet ﷺ, he would pray.*
>
> **Sunan Abi Dawud**

The Prophet ﷺ stood in prayer at night until his feet became swollen. When he was asked why, when his past and future sins had been forgiven, he said: "Should I not be a grateful servant?"
Sahih al-Bukhari and Sahih Muslim

قُلْ يَٰعِبَادِيَ ٱلَّذِينَ أَسْرَفُوا۟ عَلَىٰٓ أَنفُسِهِمْ لَا تَقْنَطُوا۟ مِن رَّحْمَةِ ٱللَّهِ ۚ إِنَّ ٱللَّهَ يَغْفِرُ ٱلذُّنُوبَ جَمِيعًا ۚ إِنَّهُۥ هُوَ ٱلْغَفُورُ ٱلرَّحِيمُ

Say, "O My servants who have transgressed against themselves [by sinning], do not despair of the mercy of Allāh. Indeed, Allāh forgives all sins. Indeed, it is He who is the Forgiving, the Merciful."
Surah az-Zumar 39:53

وَإِذْ تَأَذَّنَ رَبُّكُمْ لَئِن شَكَرْتُمْ لَأَزِيدَنَّكُمْ

And [remember] when your Lord proclaimed, 'If you are grateful, I will surely increase you [in favor].'
Surah Ibrahim 14:7

أَلَآ إِنَّ أَوْلِيَآءَ ٱللَّهِ لَا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلَا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ ﴿٦٢﴾ ٱلَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا۟ وَكَانُوا۟ يَتَّقُونَ

Unquestionably, [for] the allies of Allāh there will be no fear concerning them, nor will they grieve - those who believed and were fearing Allāh.
Surah Yunus 10:62–63

Practical exercises

The guided communication practice

1. Come into presence: picture the name of Allah in the sky, filling you with light. Remember He is with you, sees you and hears you.
2. Say Bismillah, Astaghfirullah three times, send blessings on the Prophet ﷺ, then la hawla wa la quwwata illa billah three times.
3. Present your sins to Allah one at a time, with regret, and ask Him to forgive you.
4. Thank Allah for your blessings one at a time, from the depth of your heart.
5. Bring Him your needs, your problems and the decisions you must make.
6. Put everything into a hot air balloon, watch it rise to Allah and feel the weight lift. Write how you felt.

Take your problem to the salah

1. Write down one thing worrying you today: a deadline, a child, the car, a relationship or a decision.
2. Before your next prayer, remind yourself: this is why I am going to salah, not a reason to delay it.
3. In the prayer, keep the words of the salah, and in your heart hand that matter to Allah.
4. If your mind wanders, ask what lesson the thought holds, like the crying child who keeps coming back.
5. Afterwards, write what changed in how you feel about the problem.

Talking to Allah through the day

1. Choose one daily moment to talk to Allah in your heart: driving, cooking, walking or tidying up.
2. Tell Him honestly what is on your mind, knowing He hears you and never misunderstands.
3. At bedtime, say alhamdulillah and think of one blessing each time, until you fall asleep.
4. Write down the blessings you remembered and how talking to Allah during the day felt.

7-day practice: communication

Tick each day you practise.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Did the guided communication practice							
Took a problem to the salah							
Talked to Allah in my heart during the day							
Counted blessings with alhamdulillah at bedtime							

Reflection questions and answers

1. What do you keep inside that you have never really told Allah about? What stops you?

> We can pour out whatever weighs on our heart and mind: problems, health, needs, blessings, anything at all. Many people long for someone to listen, and some even pay a counsellor just to sit and listen, yet Allah is always listening and says "I am near" (2:186). For example: I have never really told Allah how lonely I feel; what stops me is thinking it is too small or too emotional to bring to Him.

2. When something goes wrong, is your first thought to pray or to put the prayer off? How could you change that?

> Whenever something distressed the Prophet ﷺ, he turned to prayer. The shift in mentality is to see the spreadsheet that will not balance, the child's tantrum or the broken-down car as a reason to go to salah, not a reason to say "I've not got time to pray." For example: when things go wrong I usually put the prayer off until things calm down; I could change this by praying first and handing the problem to Allah in my heart.

3. How does the hadith of the piece of gold change the way you see thoughts that come to you in prayer?

> In Sahih al-Bukhari, the Prophet ﷺ hurried home after a prayer because he had remembered a piece of gold there and did not want it to stay overnight, so he had it given away; it is also reported that Umar would organise his armies in prayer. The lesson is that the thought itself is not the problem; it is what you do with it, so bring it to Allah. For example: instead of feeling I have failed when I remember a bill, I can ask Allah to help me with it.

4. Which of the five (sins, blessings, needs, problems, decisions) was easiest to bring to Allah, and which was hardest? Why?

> The five things to bring are sins (one at a time, with regret, even the ones we have not forgiven ourselves for), blessings (one at a time, with thanks), needs (things in the future), problems (things happening now) and decisions (Allah knows every outcome). A good answer names one easy and one hard, and why. For example: blessings were easiest because thanking Allah felt natural; sins were hardest because facing them made me feel ashamed, though 39:53 tells us never to despair of His mercy.

5. Which blessings did you remember that you usually take for granted?

> The session suggests thanking Allah for one blessing at a time: your eyes, ears, children, home and health. Allah promises that if we are grateful He will increase us (14:7), and the speaker's father falls asleep saying alhamdulillah for one blessing after another. For example: I remembered my eyesight, clean running water and my children's laughter, which I rarely stop to thank Allah for.

6. How did it feel to put everything into the hot air balloon and send it to Allah?

> After bringing our sins, blessings, needs, problems and decisions, we put everything into a hot air balloon, watch it rise to Allah and feel the burden lift off our chest. The aim is for salah to become the place where burdens are lifted rather than the place where they distract us. For example: it felt like a weight coming off my shoulders, and for the first time in a while I finished feeling lighter rather than more anxious.

7. What would it mean for you to have Allah as your closest friend, and what small step could take you there this week?

> Practising this communication all day, while driving, cooking or in any situation, means Allah gradually becomes your closest friend. The awliya (friends of Allah) have no fear and do not grieve, and they have two qualities: they believe and they are conscious of Allah (10:62–63); in a hadith qudsi, Allah declares war on whoever shows enmity to a friend of His. For example: it would mean never feeling alone, and my small step this week is talking to Allah in my heart each time I drive to work.

My action plan

- [ ] I will do the guided communication practice at least once a day this week.
- [ ] When something distresses me, I will go to the salah to solve it instead of delaying the prayer.
- [ ] I will talk to Allah in my heart while driving, cooking or walking.
- [ ] I will count my blessings with alhamdulillah as I fall asleep.
- [ ] I will bring my next big decision to Allah and ask Him to guide me.
- [ ] I will share this practice with my family, and remind my children that Allah is their Creator.